PIA3142
GLOBAL SOCIAL MOVEMENTS

CITY UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG, DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC & INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS
SEMESTER A, A.Y. 2026/27; MONDAYS, 9:00–11:50; LOCATION: LAU, 5-206

TEACHING STAFF

Dr. Federico FERRARA, Associate Professor (PIA) | fferrara@cityu.edu.hk

COURSE DESCRIPTION

When do movements arise? What do the organizers do to mobilize people and motivate them to stay? How do they deal with fence-sitters and movement foes? Why do some movements scale up and become transnational? Why do movements dissipate? This course, designed as an overview of the social movements and contentious politics literature, will help you explore these questions. We will go over the primary theoretical building blocks, such as political opportunities, resource mobilization, and framing, and apply them to specific cases. Students will investigate movements of their choice for a research project, the results of which will be presented to the class.

ASSESSMENT

The final grade for the course is determined on the basis of a student's performance on the following:

(1) Attendance/Participation (10%): Attendance and active participation are required.

(2) Midterm Quiz (30%) and Final Quiz (30%): Quizzes will be held during normal class hours (in Week 8 and Week 13). Questions will deal with matters covered in class as well as a selection of the readings listed below (those highlighted in yellow).

(3) Presentation (30%): Each student will be assigned to a group of four or five, which will be responsible for giving a presentation on a particular social movement towards the end of the semester.

TOPICS AND READINGS

31 August 2026

WEEK 1—Introduction/Organizational Meeting

7 September 2026

WEEK 2—Social Movement Theory

REQ.: Mark I. Lichbach. 1995. *The Rebel's Dilemma*. University of Michigan Press. [Read: Ch. 1].

REC.: Jacquelien van Stekelenburg and Bert Klandermans. 2009. "Social Movement Theory: Past, Present, and Prospects." In Stephen Ellis and Ineke van Kessel (eds.), *Movers and Shakers: Social Movements in Africa*. Leiden: Brill.

14 September 2026

WEEK 3—Mobilizing for Action: Identity, Rationality, and the Emotions

REQ.: Jonathan Haidt. 2012. *The Righteous Mind: Why Good People Are Divided by Politics and Religion*. New York: Vintage Books. [Read: Ch. 7 and 9].

REC.: David A. Snow, Sarah A. Soule, and Hanspeter Kriesi. 2004. *The Blackwell Companion to Social Movements*. Malden, MA: Blackwell Publishing. [Read: Ch. 17-18].

21 September 2026

WEEK 4—Getting It Done: Saul Alinsky's *Rules for Radicals*

REC.: Saul D. Alinsky. 1971. *Rules for Radicals: A Pragmatic Primer for Realistic Radicals*. Random House.

28 September 2026

WEEK 5—The Dynamics of Collective Mobilization

REQ.: Erica Chenoweth. 2020. "Questions, Answers, and Some Cautionary Updates Regarding the 3.5% Rule." Harvard University: Carr Center for Human Rights Policy Discussion Paper.

REC.: Rasma Karklins and Roger Peterson. 1993. "The Decision Calculus of Protesters and Regimes: Eastern Europe, 1989." Journal of Politics: 588-614.

5 October 2026

WEEK 6— MIDTERM QUIZ

12 October 2026

WEEK 7— The Relationship Between Protest and Repression

REQ.: Ronald A Francisco. 2010. *Collective Action Theory and Empirical Evidence*. New York: Springer. [Read: Ch. 3-4].

REC.: Ronald A Francisco. 2004. "After the Massacre: Mobilization in the Wake of Harsh Repression." *Mobilization* 9: 107-126.

19 October 2026

WEEK 8—NO CLASS (Day following Chung Yeung Festival)

26 October 2026

WEEK 9—The Art of Disorder and the Struggle for State Power

REC.: Federico Ferrara. 2026. *The Edge of Chaos: Disorder as a Political Weapon*. Unpublished manuscript.

2 November 2026

WEEK 10—Asia's "People Power" Movements and the Struggle for Freedom and Equality

REQ.: George Katsiaficas. 2013. *Asia's Unknown Uprisings, Vol. 2*. Oakland: PM Press. [Read: Ch. 1].

REC.: Joshua Kurlantzick. 2013. *Democracy in Retreat: The Revolt of the Middle Class and the Worldwide Decline of Representative Government*. Yale University Press. [Read: Ch. 1-5].

9 November 2026

WEEK 11— Globalization, Transnational Movements, and the Future of Contentious Politics

REQ.: Valentine M. Moghadam. 2009. *Globalization and Social Movements: Islamism, Feminism, and the Global Justice Movement*. Lanham, MD: Rowman & Littlefield. [Read: Ch. 3].

REQ.: Erica Chenoweth. 2020. "The Future of Nonviolent Resistance." *Journal of Democracy* 31: 69-84.

16 November 2026

WEEK 12—PRESENTATIONS

23 November 2026

WEEK 13—FINAL QUIZ

ACADEMIC HONESTY

Rules on academic honesty: https://www.cityu.edu.hk/pvdp/ah/ah-rules.htm

Online tutorial on academic honesty: https://www.cityu.edu.hk/ah/

Guidelines on use of Generative AI tools: https://www.cityu.edu.hk/GenAI/guidelines.htm

PIA Head's letter concerning academic honesty: Read on Canvas (click on the "Files" tab)